

פנחס has a number of massive topics, some more well-known than others. One of the topics that doesn't get as much attention or isn't learned as much as the others appears right before the section of the ימים טובים. Hashem is having a discussion with Moshe (27:15): וַיֹּדֶבֶר מֹשֶׁה אֶל ה' לֵאמֹר: An unusual pasuk. He wants to have a successor appointed. What does Hashem tell him? וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה קח לך אֶת יְהוֹשֻׁעַ בֶּן נּוּן אִישׁ אֵשֶׁר רוּחַ בּוֹ וְסִמְכָתָּ: וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה קח לך אֶת יְהוֹשֻׁעַ בֶּן נּוּן אִישׁ אֵשֶׁר רוּחַ בּוֹ וְסִמְכָתָּ: What happens a couple of בפרקים later? מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה? וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה? וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה? Hashem said to Moshe וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה, singular, and it says וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה, plural. וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה on the spot says, וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה - beautifully, with a generous eye; וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה - Hashem said "You should put your hand", and he did it with two hands; וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה - The ברכה he gave was as if he was filling a vessel to full and overflowing. What does וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה mean by וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּיַד מֹשֶׁה?

R' Chaim Kanievsky brings down that the Dubno Maggid asked the Vilna Gaon, how is it that a צדיק positively influences the people around him? The Gaon explained: imagine you have a becher surrounded by a whole series of smaller bechers, with little conduits from the big becher to the small ones. If you fill up the large becher, and you keep on filling it and it overflows, then all the little bechers right next to the big becher become filled as well. However, if the big becher is filled and you pour off from it into all the other little bechers, the big becher will be left empty. But if you keep pouring into the big becher, it overflows. Similarly, the Gaon said, if the person who's a מנהיג, who's a משפיע, a person who has the opportunity and the זכות to influence those around him, if he works on his תורה ויראת שמים, there'll be a trickle down effect, it'll influence those who are around him. However, if a person stops at a certain level of תורה ויראה and does not continue to improve himself and wants to give others, he will not succeed. That's what רש"י says. משה filled יהושע overflowing. He gave so much of his own מדות of תורה ויראת שמים and with the addition of יהושע's own attainments, he would be worthy of leading כלל ישראל.

He brings down a מדרש that רבי עקיבא was able to continue the מסורה with just seven תלמידים, by filling them up so that they could continue to grow. He brings another example of the חזון איש, one single person turned בני ברק into what בני ברק is, sitting in his אמות of learning תורה, his השפעה was so overwhelming that he created an entire בני ברק. So we see that לימוד התורה is an ongoing process, and we have to continue to work on ourselves, to make ourselves better and to have an influence on all those around us.

A separate vort on the פרשה from the sefer פלאות התורה has to do with the census that was taken. The sefer has a large number of דברי תורה on the name יששכר, which of course makes me interested because that's my name. So there's a sefer called בני יששכר, written by R' Tzvi Elimelech of Dinov. Why did he name it בני יששכר? It's brought down in the sefer שלמה בית that one time he went to his Rebbe, none other than the Chozeh of Lublin, and asked him, "Rebbi, can you tell me which שבט I'm from?" He explained that every year when חנוכה comes, he feels a tremendous תשוקה, a powerful emotional connection to the mitzvah of חנוכה. הדלקת נר חנוכה. More than other מצוות, he feels drawn to this one in particular. He said, "I know I'm not a כהן, so I can't be descended from the חשמונאים. So where does this feeling come from?"

Even before he finished asking, the Chozev of Lublin answered, “שבט יששכר is from תשוקה. You’re a descendant of those who were part of the בית דין at the time of the השמונים. The בית דין was made up of שבט יששכר, the teachers of כלל ישראל. They were the ones who gave direction and השפעה to כלל ישראל. That’s why your נשמה has such a yearning for this mitzvah.” In the זכות of hearing this תורה דבר, he was so inspired that he named his famous sefer בני יששכר, which is a sefer on all the ימים טובים and the months of the year.

We see a living proof of how this yearning, this self improvement has a direct influence on us. בעזרת השם, we should learn from all of these lessons that as we continue to improve ourselves, we can have a positive influence on all of כלל ישראל.

